



Why **fall?** Because science.

As the days grow shorter and temperatures start to cool, you might be thinking about winding down time spent in the garden. However, did you know that fall is actually one of the best times of the year to plant and garden? Not an opinion. This is science.

Fall is for planting. **Here's why:**



WARM SOIL = FASTER ROOT ESTABLISHMENT.

Roots play an important role in plant growth because they are the plant part that absorbs water and nutrients from the soil. Unlike in spring, when the soil is often cool and wet, **fall's warmer soil encourages roots to grow quickly** and establish themselves before winter arrives. This strong root system will support robust growth when spring returns.



REDUCED PLANT STRESS.

Unlike the hot and often dry summer months, **fall's milder climate allows plants to establish themselves** without the added burden of extreme heat. This means they can **focus more energy on root development** rather than struggling to survive in the heat.



FEWER PESTS AND DISEASES.

As temperatures drop, pests like aphids, beetles, and caterpillars become less active, **giving your plants a better chance to thrive** without the constant fear of being eaten or infected.



CONSISTENT RAINFALL.

This helps keep the soil moist and reduces the need for frequent watering. Plus, **cooler temperatures reduce evaporation**, ensuring that the moisture stays where it's needed – in the root zone.



EXTENDING THE GROWING SEASON.

In the fall, plants have the opportunity to establish themselves before winter, leading to a head start in the spring. Perennials, shrubs, and trees planted in the fall will begin **growing earlier and more vigorously** when the warmer weather returns, giving them a significant advantage over those planted in the spring.



END-OF-SEASON FALL GARDEN MAINTENANCE GUIDE

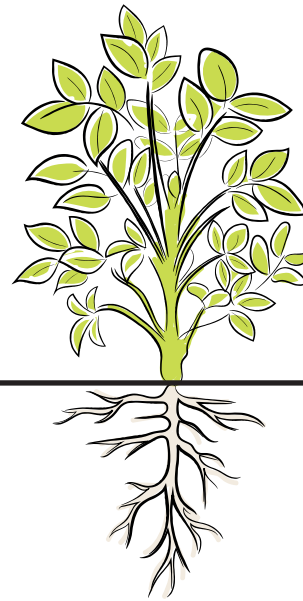
Fall is for planting *essentials* guide:

The growing season in our region is 220 days long – and with 63 days left before the predicted first frost, we still have over 28% of the season left to make an impact in our landscapes. It's almost the fourth quarter – so we've created a guide to help you crush the fall season.

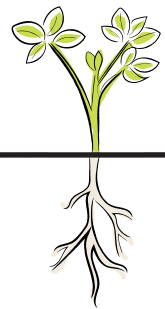
Fall offers the perfect mix of cooler temperatures and soil warmth, creating ideal conditions for planting. This season gives new plants a head start on root development, allowing them to establish well before winter.

Additionally, planting in the fall means less watering and maintenance compared to summer. Whether you're starting a new garden or enhancing your landscape, *fall is the time to set your garden up for success next spring.*

2025
fall planted



2026
spring
planted



What you'll likely need:



SOIL PH TESTS OR SOIL KIT.

Be proactive! If you don't know your pH, **you're leaving a huge question mark on the table** down the road should you need to troubleshoot plant stress or failure.



ESPOMA® MUSHROOM COMPOST.

A rich, organic soil amendment that **improves soil structure and fertility**, providing vital nutrients to support root development during fall planting.



LEAFGRO® COMPOST.

This high-quality compost **enhances soils' organic matter, promoting better drainage and aeration.** It's ideal for preparing garden beds for fall plantings and spring bulbs.



END-OF-SEASON FALL GARDEN MAINTENANCE GUIDE



MULCH OR STRAW.

Help **regain moisture and regulate soil temperature** with a good layer of mulch. It also **suppresses weeds and protects plants** from harsh winter conditions.



FALL GRASS SEED.

Fall is the best time to **establish or repair lawns**, with cooler temperatures and increased moisture encouraging strong root growth.



BONIDE® CAPTAIN JACK'S® DEADWEED BREW.

Weeds are back! A **fast-acting herbicide that helps clear out weeds**. It's organic and safe for use around edible plants.



QUALITY HAND PRUNERS.

Essential for trimming back perennials, shrubs, and trees. **Fall is a great time for pruning** as plants are beginning to go dormant, reducing stress from cuts.



SHADE CLOTHS FOR COOL-SEASON VEGGIES.

Protect lettuce, spinach, and other cool-season vegetables from **intense sunlight during warm days**.



FROST COVERS.

Protect tender plants from early frosts, helping them thrive longer into the season. Frost covers are **lightweight and breathable, offering gentle protection**.



END-OF-SEASON FALL GARDEN MAINTENANCE GUIDE



FALL-PLANTED BULBS.

Plant bulbs like tulips, daffodils, and Crocuses now for a stunning display. Fall planting gives them the **cold period needed to bloom beautifully.**



PERENNIALS.

Now's the time to plant perennials to give them a **strong start before next spring.** Add fall bloomers like Asters and *Helenium* if you're looking to **support migrating pollinators.**



TREES & SHRUBS.

Fall's cool weather and warm soil **create ideal conditions for tree and shrub planting.** Roots establish well without the stress of summer heat, less watering too.

7 WEEKS LEFT · SEPTEMBER 11-17

Task 1: *Build healthy soil.*

Have you ever heard the saying “dig a twenty-dollar hole for a ten-dollar tree”? It's a reminder that **healthy soil is the foundation of a thriving garden.** Whether you're planting food, flowers, shrubs, or trees, your soil is crucial to your garden's success.

- ☐ **Do a soil test** for any areas of your garden that you would like to improve to get a better understanding of it. Lawns, trees, flower beds, and veggie gardens can all benefit from attention to soil health.
- ☐ **Ensure that your soil has enough organic matter** to support healthy plant development. Organic matter should be at least 2% on a soil test and should be in the 5-10% range for veggie and flower beds.
- ☐ **Add organic matter** by spreading 1" of the soil amendment of your choice. Consider trying manure, compost, leaves, grass clippings, cover crops, biosolids, pine bark fines, or worm castings.



7 WEEKS LEFT · SEPTEMBER 11-17

Task 2: Sow veggie seeds.

In our region, you can still sow cool-season crops like spinach, kale, lettuce, radishes, carrots, and beets in the fall before the first frost. Growing your own food not only ensures fresh, flavorful produce — **it reduces your carbon footprint and grocery costs.**

- ☐ **Know your soil type.** Cool-season seeds thrive in nutrient-rich, loamy soil with a balanced mixture of sand, silt, and clay. They'll need consistent moisture until they germinate.
- ☐ **Buy seeds, taking into account when they'll be ready to harvest.** Count back from Nov. 7th (first predicted frost) to determine if your chosen varieties have enough time to harvest.
- ☐ **Cool-season veggies typically need 4-6 hours of direct sunlight a day.** Too much sun and soil that is too warm may be detrimental to your plantings.

Suggested shopping list for week 1 tasks:

- ☒ Soil test kit/Soil pH test kit
- ☒ LeafGro® or organic compost
- ☒ Mulch to insulate new plantings
- ☒ Cool season veggie seeds (*think leafy greens, brassicas root veggies*)
- ☒ Raised bed potting mix
- ☒ Frost covers and shade clothes (*to protect sensitive crops from extreme sun and cold*)



6 WEEKS LEFT · SEPTEMBER 18-24

A weekend for *lawn care tasks*.

Seeding and feeding your lawn in the fall is a great way to repair summer damage and prepare it for a healthy, lush spring. **We trust Jonathan Green® products** because they've consistently delivered great results, helping your lawn thrive year after year.

☐ Task 1 | Dethatch and aerate.

Begin by mowing to expose thatch layer. Then dethatch thoroughly to remove dead grass, leaves, and debris. Follow up with aeration to improve soil compaction.



Task 2 | Balance Soil pH with Mag-I-Cal®.

Healthy soil is the foundation for strong root development, and this step will help the nutrients you apply work more effectively.



Task 3 | Prepare the Soil with Love your Soil®.

This product enriches the soil with microbes, ensuring the roots of our grass grow deeper and your lawn thrives season after season.



Task 4 | Seed with Black Beauty™ Fall Magic.

This specially formulated seed mix is ideal for fall planting, helping fill in bare spots and improve the overall appearance of your lawn.



6 WEEKS LEFT · SEPTEMBER 18-24



Task 5 | Feed with Veri-Green® Starter Fertilizer.

Apply after seeding to provide seeds with the nutrients they need to germinate effectively and establish strong roots.



Task 6 | Grow deeper with Winter Survival.

This gentle fall feeding for established grass can be applied now through mid-November. This fertilizer promotes deeper root growth, resulting in greener grass early next spring.

Suggested shopping list for week 2 tasks:



Dethatching rake and aerator



Broadcast spreader or drop seeder



Soil test kit/Soil pH test kit



Jonathan Green® products

- Balance soil pH with Mag-I-Cal®
- Prepare the soil with Love Your Soil®
- Seed with Black Beauty™ Fall Magic
- Feed with Veri-Green® Starter Fertilizer
- Grow deeper with Winter Survival



5 WEEKS LEFT · SEPT. 25-OCT. 1

Put the pruners down.

It's natural to want to tidy up the garden as the weather cools, **but pruning in the fall can actually do more harm than good.** Pruning encourages new growth – this growth is tender and can easily be damaged by the cold, weakening your plants.

By waiting until late winter or early spring, you're allowing your plants to stay strong through the winter and emerge healthier in the new season. **Here are a few other tasks that you can focus on:**

☐ Task 1 | Divide perennials and bulbs.

Now is the perfect time to dig up and divide overcrowded perennials and bulbs. This helps them grow stronger next year and prevents overcrowding.



Step 1

Using a spade or garden fork, dig around the plant and gently lift it out of the ground.

Don't worry, this process won't hurt them. Once the plant is out of the ground, carefully separate the roots or bulbs into smaller sections using your hands or a garden knife like a Hori-Hori. Each divided piece should have healthy roots and some leaves or stems.

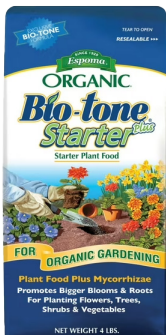


Step 2

Dig a new hole for each section and replant them at the same depth as before. Water them well and add Bio-tone® to help them re-establish and a little mulch to help protect them through the winter.

☐ Task 2 | Add fall color.

Refresh your garden with cold-hardy annuals like pansies and ornamental cabbages. They bring vibrant color to your landscape as other plants start to fade.



Task 3 | Feed your plants.

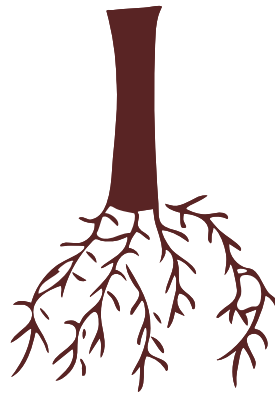
Apply Bio-tone® – a slow-release fertilizer with **mycorrhizae** to nourish your plants' roots through winter. This helps them build strength during dormancy and get off to a strong start in spring.

Mycorr...what?

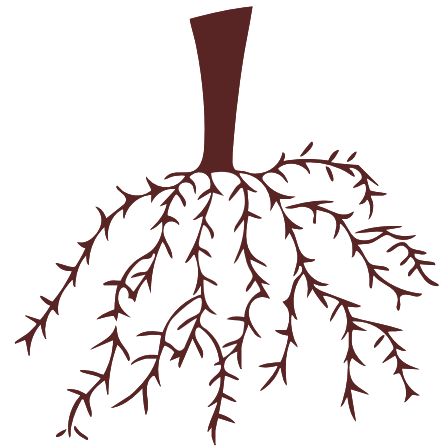
Mycorrhizae are fungi that work with the roots of plants to help each other – the plant and the fungus both get something good from this relationship.

The fungi has **root-like structures, called mycelium**, that spread into the soil beyond what the plant's roots can reach. This mycelium collects nutrients from the soil and delivers them to the plant. In return the plant provides the fungi with sugars since they don't photosynthesize.

This partnership **increases the plant's ability to absorb nutrients**, helping it grow better and stronger.



NO MYCORRHIZAE



WITH MYCORRHIZAE

Suggested shopping list for week 3 tasks:

✓ Spade/garden fork/garden knife

✓ Espoma® Bio-tone® Starter Plus

✓ Cool-season annuals



4 WEEKS LEFT · OCTOBER 2-8

This weekend is all about planting.

Look — we'd be the first ones to urge you to spend a few hours in the garden center picking out plants that inspire you. However, **plant selection isn't the first step**. In fact, it should be one of the last.

Fall is the perfect time to evaluate your garden and fill in any functional gaps. Beyond aesthetics, **plants contribute to a balanced ecosystem** and enhance your landscape's utility.

Yes — we want you to go crazy with plant buying this weekend. But first, **let's learn how to assess our landscapes** in a way that prioritizes functionality.

Here's a guide to help you assess your garden:



NATIVE HABITAT.

Are native plants present? Native plant species support local wildlife, including birds and beneficial insects. **Shop our Native Habitat section** in all retail stores to find a wide selection of native trees, shrubs, and perennials that enhance habitat.



SUCCESSIVE BLOOMS.

Do you have blooms from early spring through late fall? **Pollinators need a continuous source of nectar**. Ensure there are different flowering species that bloom at various times to support pollinators year-round. Remember, herbaceous perennials aren't the only things that bloom. Trees and shrubs do as well.



STRUCTURE WITH SHRUBS.

Is your landscape lacking structure? Shrubs create a backbone and year-round interest. **They provide shelter for wildlife**, add height, and can serve as windbreaks.



STORMWATER MANAGEMENT.

Is your lawn dense and healthy? **A well-maintained lawn prevents soil erosion and filters rainwater**. Overseed, aerate, and use compost to build soil health and ensure strong turf.



EDIBLE OPTIONS.

Think back on the season; did you wish you had planted edible plants? Fruit trees, berry shrubs, and perennial herbs **add both beauty and food value**. Consider incorporating them into your landscape for fresh produce.



SEASONAL COLOR.

Are patios and pathways softened with plants? Use container gardening to **add greenery to hard surfaces**. Containers of ornamental grasses, seasonal flowers, or ornamental veggies can **bring life to these spaces**.

Right plant for the **right place**.

Now that we know the purpose of our plants, we must remember that we can't just plant anything. We need to **consider how much light and moisture the area receives** to narrow down our plant list even further. For example, as much as you'd like to pick blueberries with the kids, you will not find success planting them in a shady spot.



Our associates are happy to help you find the perfect plant to fit your intentions. We also have a **full-service Landscape Division with accredited designers** who can work with you to create the garden of your dreams.

What if I need to add a garden bed?

Maybe you look around and your current landscape needs an entirely new bed or collection of plants to enhance both functionality and aesthetics. Fall is a great time to begin that process. Here's how you can **start a new garden bed organically, without the use of chemicals**, and ready in time for spring planting.

- ☐ Visualize where you'd like your new bed to be. You can even **outline the shape of it** with a garden hose. Remember, straight lines rarely occur in nature, and **curved borders give a more natural look**.
- ☐ Lay down cardboard or thick newspaper directly over the lawn to smother grass and weeds.
- ☐ Add organic matter by topping with a thick layer of compost and mulch.
- ☐ Let it decompose through the fall and winter. Allow it to sit for a few months. You can always refine your bed's shape and border in the spring with a spade.



Now, *go buy plants!*

Fall is for planting – **cooler temperatures, warm soil, and reliable rainfall** make it perfect for establishing perennials, trees, and shrubs.



3 WEEKS LEFT · OCTOBER 9-15

Fall-planted bulbs for spring blooms.

Planting bulbs in the fall can feel intimidating, but it's a simple, rewarding way to enjoy beautiful blooms next spring. **Let's walk through the process step-by-step**, so you feel confident and excited about this weekend's tasks.

Here's a guide to help get you planting:

☐ **Access your landscape.** Bulbs are pretty versatile — they can add new color, vary the height and sight lines of your garden, or fill in gaps. Know that bulbs prefer a sight with well-drained soil as **bulbs can rot in overly wet conditions**.

☐ **Planting depth.** A general rule of thumb is to **plant bulbs at a depth that's about three times their height**. For example, if a bulb is 2 inches tall, plant it 6 inches deep. Be sure to plant them pointy side up — that's where the shoot will emerge.



Add nutrients with Bulb-tone®.

Sprinkle some **Espoma® Bulb Tone®** into the soil as you plant. This **slow-release organic fertilizer** gives bulbs the nutrients they need for strong roots and vibrant blooms. Water well after you backfill with soil.

☐ **Care until spring.** Once planted, **bulbs don't need a lot of attention**. After the initial watering, let nature take care of the rest. Winter rains and snows will provide enough moisture. As spring approaches, you'll start to see green shoots pushing through the soil.

Suggested shopping list for week 5 tasks:

- ☒ Hand trowel, bulb planter, or auger
- ☒ Espoma® Bulb-tone®
- ☒ Plant markers to label where you planted bulbs
- ☒ Fall planted bulbs

Bringing houseplants indoors for fall.

As outdoor temperatures consistently dip below 50°F, **it's time to bring your houseplants back inside.** But, doing just that isn't enough. You'll need to do a few other things to help them acclimate back indoors.

Here's a step-by-step guide to help get you started:



INSPECT FOR PESTS.

Inspect leaves (top and underside), stems, and soil. **Remove any visible pests** by wiping them off with a damp cloth, spraying with insecticidal soap, or using neem oil.



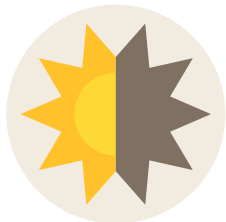
CLEAN THEM UP.

Give your plants a thorough cleaning. Remove any dead or yellowing leaves, prune away leggy growth, and clean the leaves with a damp cloth to remove dust and debris.



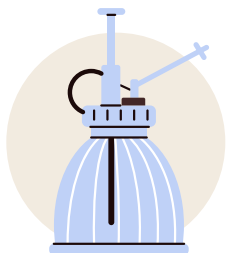
REPOT IF NEEDED.

If any plants have outgrown their pots, **now is a good time to repot them** into slightly larger containers with fresh soil.



HARDEN OFF.

Houseplants need time to adjust to indoor conditions. **Move them into a shaded, sheltered outdoor area for a few days (during the day) to help them acclimate** before bringing them inside. This **gradual transition** reduces shock from the change in light and humidity levels.



ADJUST YOUR WATERING.

Once indoors, reduce watering. **Plants typically need less water in the fall and winter** due to slower growth and less evaporation indoors. Allow the top inch of soil to dry out between waterings, but avoid letting the plant dry out completely.



2 WEEKS LEFT · OCTOBER 16-22



SUPPLEMENTAL LIGHTING.

If natural light is limited, consider using grow lights to supplement.



SUPPLEMENTAL HUMIDITY.

Indoor air can be quite dry in the fall and winter. **Increase humidity around your plants** by grouping them together, placing them on trays filled with water and pebbles, or using a humidifier. **Misting is generally not as effective** for increasing humidity.



NO NEED TO FERTILIZE.

Most houseplants go into a dormant or slower growth phase during the winter. **It's best to pause fertilizing** during this time and resume in the spring when growth picks up again.

1 WEEK LEFT · OCTOBER 23-29

Congratulations!

Closing the garden for the winter is no easy feat — congratulations on hard work well done. It will surely pay off as the spring equinox arrives this coming March and you are rewarded with a healthy, energized landscape and garden. **So, where do we go from here?**



CAN I STILL PLANT THINGS?

You can plant hardy plants so long as the soil is workable — a sign that soil temperature is warm enough for root establishment. Just know that anything tender above ground will terminate once your area begins to receive frost. Even if you have had several nights with frost, the soil will not freeze hard until you've had continuous days and nights where temperatures stay below 32°F.



TIPS FOR LATE-FALL PLANTINGS.

Water generously after planting and **keep watering until the ground freezes** to prevent new plants from drying out. Apply mulch to new plantings to help with moisture and temperature control. **No need to fertilize at this time.**



PREP THE SOIL FOR SPRING NOW.

Spread a layer of compost over garden beds. This will **slowly break down over winter**, enriching your soil for next spring.



LEAVE THE LEAVES (AND SEED HEADS).

A valid excuse to not have to rake! **The nitrogen in fallen leaves is a natural fertilizer for your yard** and the tree roots below the soil. They also provide shelter for many species of wildlife. Allow plants like *Echinacea* (coneflower) and *Rudbeckia* (black-eyed Susan) to stand. Their seed heads provide winter food for birds. Native bees utilize the hollow stems of spent perennials to overwinter. If you must prune them back, think about laying the stalks under a tree so they can still be utilized.



TURN OFF YOUR IRRIGATION SYSTEM AND SPIGOTS.

Before any word of temps dipping below freezing, be sure to **disconnect hoses**, drain them, and store them indoors to prevent cracking. If you have an irrigation system, be sure to **blow out any remaining water** to prevent frozen pipes. **Turn off your spigots** until spring.



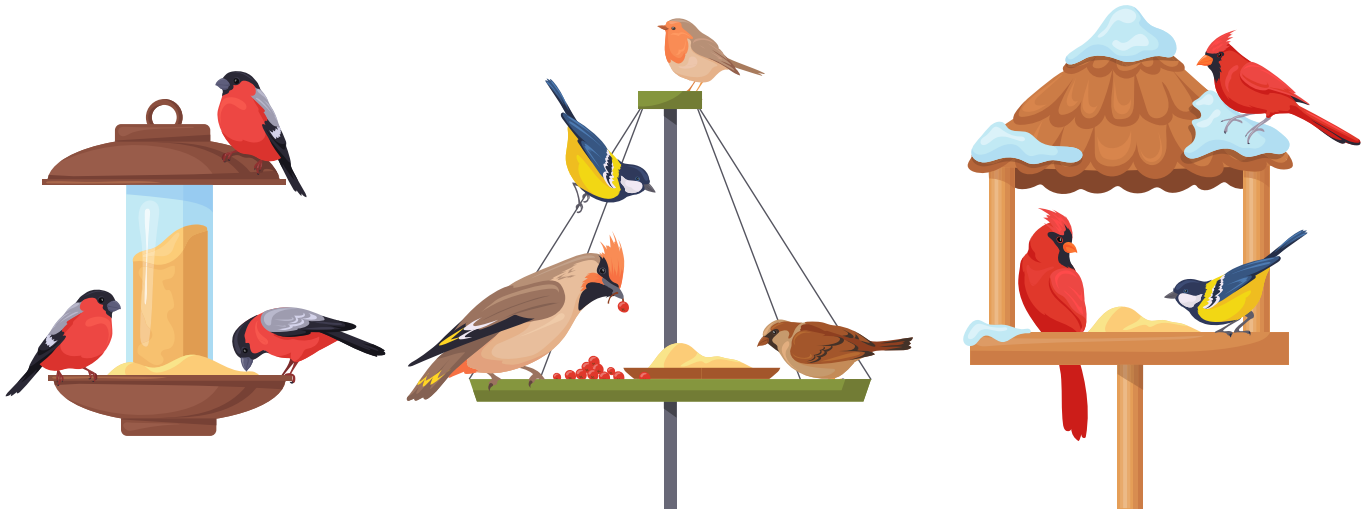
1 WEEK LEFT · OCTOBER 23-29

As the garden *settles into winter rest..*

..many of us feel a bit of sadness knowing that our time tending to the garden will pause for a few months. But don't worry — **there are plenty of ways to stay connected to plants and nature** during the cold months.

Consider picking up a new hobby:

- ✔ **Supporting non-migratory birds** with feeders and suet and watching them from the window as they **stock up their energy for the winter.**
- ✔ Beat winter blues with **indoor greenery.** Tending to houseplants is an incredible way to **keep your thumbs green** while the outdoor plants take a rest.



However you choose to spend the late-fall and winter months, **know that Homestead Gardens is open year-round to support you** and your green aspirations. We invite you to visit and strike up a conversation **with one of our knowledgeable associates** any time.